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Teachers' Guide to University 2027

The key higher education facts for school and college staff

The benefits of attending a summer school

By Shay Jordan, Outreach Officer at the University of East Anglia

Summer schools are an opportunity for your students to spend time on a university campus to develop their knowledge and understanding of higher education. Research shows that participation in summer schools leads to higher attainment and progression to university. This article looks at two types of summer school and how each can benefit your students.

Subject summer schools

Many universities run summer schools centred around a specific subject. These events aim to spark interests and provide an insight into studying that subject at a higher level. Students leave with greater confidence and excitement about their educational journey. They may also develop a deeper understanding of how the learning on their current course applies beyond the classroom.

For example, a pharmacy or medicine summer school may allow participants to spend time in GP surgeries or other medical settings. A creative writing summer school might help participants develop their portfolios, guided by experienced writers. An engineering summer school might allow participants to use industry-standard equipment, and work collaboratively to develop practical solutions to real-world problems.

Non-subject summer schools

Several universities run summer schools which aren't subject-specific. These allow participants to develop a sense of place and belonging, making higher education feel more familiar, accessible, and achievable. They also allow students to develop the skills for success in education.

These events could involve sessions exploring different aspects of student life, including students' union activities, representation, societies, wellbeing, course choices, study abroad opportunities, and placements. These summer schools often task students with a project throughout the event. This allows them to develop essential skills such as communication, teamwork, and problem-solving.

Someone like me

Students often leave summer schools with a stronger sense that university is for "someone like me" and a greater understanding of how their skills and behaviours will support their transition into higher education.

There are hundreds of summer schools offered by institutions across the UK and beyond. Many are aimed at Year 12 students, but there are also opportunities for Key Stages 3 and 4, where early interventions can have a lasting impact. You can search for summer schools on [UniTasterDays.com](https://www.unitasterdays.com).

As with many university outreach programmes, the greatest benefits are found in the feelings they evoke. Your students will gain confidence from trying something new, friendships with other participants, first-hand insight shared by student ambassadors, and the opportunity to spend time in a university environment.

Ultimately, a successful summer school does more than inform students about university. It helps them begin to imagine themselves there. It is that shift in confidence, aspiration, and self-belief that often proves to be the most enduring benefit of all.

